StackOne

Email Setup Guide

Receiving and Sending Email via the Gmail Interface

Domain: thestackone.com
Powered by AWS SES + Gmail

This guide explains how emails addressed to @thestackone.com are automatically forwarded to your Gmail inbox, and how to configure Gmail so you can send emails from your custom address (e.g. chungu@thestackone.com) directly within the Gmail interface.

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1. Overview

StackOne uses Amazon Web Services Simple Email Service (AWS SES) to handle all email for the thestackone.com domain. The system is split into two complementary functions: receiving inbound email and forwarding it to Gmail, and sending outbound email through Gmail using SES as the SMTP relay. This architecture gives you the professionalism of a custom domain email address with the convenience and familiarity of the Gmail interface you already use every day.

On the receiving side, AWS SES accepts all inbound mail for @thestackone.com, stores it temporarily in an S3 bucket, and triggers an AWS Lambda function that parses each message and forwards it to the appropriate Gmail address. The forwarding preserves the original sender information so you can always see who really sent the email, and the Reply-To header is set to the original sender so replies go directly back to them.

On the sending side, Gmail is configured with SES SMTP credentials that allow you to compose new messages or reply to conversations from your @thestackone.com address. Gmail treats it as a custom "Send mail as" account, so you can choose which address to send from every time you compose a message. The setup requires a one-time configuration in Gmail Settings and then works seamlessly going forward.

2. Receiving Email

All email sent to any address @thestackone.com is automatically received by AWS SES and forwarded to your Gmail inbox. There is nothing you need to configure on the Gmail side to start receiving these messages. The forwarding happens in real time: within seconds of an email arriving at SES, it is delivered to the destination Gmail address.

2.1 How It Works

When someone sends an email to an address like chungu@thestackone.com, the following process occurs automatically behind the scenes. First, the sender's mail server looks up the MX (Mail Exchange) records for thestackone.com in DNS, which point to AWS SES. The email is then delivered to SES, which accepts the message and stores a copy in an S3 bucket for archival purposes. Simultaneously, SES triggers a Lambda function that reads the raw email from S3, parses it using the mailparser library, extracts the sender, subject, and body content, and then sends a new email via SES to the destination Gmail address. The forwarded email is formatted so that the "From" field shows the original sender's name and email address (for easy identification), while the Reply-To header is set to the original sender so that when you click Reply in Gmail, the response goes to the correct person.

2.2 Email Routing Rules

Each @thestackone.com address is mapped to one or more destination Gmail addresses. The routing table below shows exactly where each address forwards. If an email is sent to an address not listed in the table (for example, support@thestackone.com), it falls through to the default catch-all rule, which forwards to both team members.

Source Address	Forwards To
chungu@thestackone.com	chungu424@gmail.com

developer@thestackone.com	chungu424@gmail.com, clivatem@gmail.com
clivate@thestackone.com	clivatem@gmail.com
info@thestackone.com	chungu424@gmail.com, clivatem@gmail.com
Any other @thestackone.com	chungu424@gmail.com, clivatem@gmail.com

Table 1: Email routing map for thestackone.com

2.3 Understanding Forwarded Emails

When you receive a forwarded email in Gmail, it will appear with the original sender's name and email address in the "From" line, formatted as: "Sender Name [sender@email.com]" with the Reply-To header pointing to the original sender. This means you can simply click Reply in Gmail and your response will be addressed to the person who actually sent the email, not to the forwarding system.

It is important to note that because the email is forwarded through thestackone.com's SES infrastructure, some email clients may display a small "via thestackone.com" notice near the sender information. This is normal and indicates the email was relayed through our mail server. It does not affect the ability to reply or the deliverability of your responses.

3. Sending Email via Gmail

To send emails from your @thestackone.com address within Gmail, you need to add it as a "Send mail as" account. This is a one-time setup that takes about five minutes. Once configured, you will be able to select your custom address from the "From" dropdown every time you compose a new email or reply to a conversation. Gmail will route the email through AWS SES using SMTP, ensuring proper delivery and authentication.

3.1 Prerequisites

Before you begin, make sure you have the following information handy. You will need to enter these details during the Gmail setup process. Keep this guide open for reference as you go through the steps.

Setting	Value
SMTP Server	email-smtp.us-east-1.amazonaws.com
Port	587

Username	AKIARQIUGT6TYQPQDSEV
Password	BP6m6pBVyclpwOJiU3XiAJ6CKCLy6lpajDEt2nLAyq2q
Security	TLS (required)

Table 2: AWS SES SMTP credentials for Gmail

3.2 Step-by-Step Gmail Configuration

Follow these steps carefully to add your @thestackone.com email address as a "Send mail as" account in Gmail. The entire process is done within Gmail's Settings page and does not require any external tools or software.

Step 1: Open Gmail Settings

Log in to your Gmail account at mail.google.com. Click the gear icon in the top-right corner of the Gmail interface, then click "See all settings" from the dropdown menu. This will open the full Gmail Settings page where you can configure all aspects of your account.

Step 2: Navigate to "Accounts and Import"

In the Settings page, click on the "Accounts and Import" tab along the top navigation bar. This tab contains all the settings related to managing multiple email addresses and importing data. Look for the section titled "Send mail as" which lists all the email addresses you can currently send from.

Step 3: Add Another Email Address

In the "Send mail as" section, click the link that says "Add another email address". A popup window will appear where you will enter the details for your custom email address. Make sure your browser allows popups from Gmail, or this window may be blocked.

Step 4: Enter Your Name and Email Address

In the popup window, fill in the following fields. For "Name", enter your display name as you want it to appear to recipients (for example, "Chungu Chama"). For "Email address", enter your custom address, for example: chungu@thestackone.com. Leave the "Treat as an alias" checkbox checked, which is the default setting. Then click "Next Step" to continue.

Step 5: Configure the SMTP Server

On the next screen, you will configure the SMTP server that Gmail will use to send your emails. Enter the following details exactly as shown in Table 2 above:

SMTP Server: email-smtp.us-east-1.amazonaws.com

Port: 587

Username: AKIARQIUGT6TYQPQDSEV

Password: BP6m6pBVyclpwOJiU3XiAJ6CKCLy6lpajDEt2nLAyq2q

Secured connection using: TLS (select the radio button)

Note: Make sure you select TLS, not SSL. The SES SMTP server on port 587 requires a TLS connection. SSL on port 465 is a different protocol and will not work with these credentials.

Step 6: Save and Verify

Click "Add Account" to save your settings. Gmail will then send a verification email to chungu@thestackone.com to confirm that you own the address. Because of the forwarding setup described in Section 2, this verification email will be automatically forwarded to your Gmail inbox. Open the verification email and either click the confirmation link or enter the confirmation code back in the Gmail popup window. Once verified, the setup is complete.

Step 7: Test Your Setup

After verification, compose a new email in Gmail. Click the "From" field in the compose window and you should now see chungu@thestackone.com as an option. Select it and send a test email to another address you control. Verify that the recipient sees the email as coming from chungu@thestackone.com and that replies to that email are delivered back to your Gmail inbox.

3.3 Choosing Your Default "From" Address

Once you have added your custom email address, you can choose whether Gmail uses it or your regular Gmail address as the default when composing new messages. In Gmail Settings, under the "Accounts and Import" tab and the "Send mail as" section, you will see a radio button next to each address. Select the one you want to use as the default. You can also configure Gmail to automatically reply from the same address the message was sent to, which is recommended for a seamless experience. Look for the "When replying to a message" option and select "Reply from the same address the message was sent to". This ensures that when someone emails chungu@thestackone.com and you reply, the response comes from chungu@thestackone.com rather than your @gmail.com address.

4. Troubleshooting

This section covers the most common issues you may encounter when receiving or sending email and provides clear steps to resolve them.

4.1 Not Receiving Forwarded Emails

If emails sent to your @thestackone.com address are not arriving in your Gmail inbox, first check your Gmail Spam folder. Gmail's spam filters occasionally route forwarded emails to spam, especially for newly set up domains. If you find the emails in spam, mark them as "Not spam" to train Gmail's filter. If the emails are not in spam, check the AWS SES dashboard in the AWS Management Console (us-east-1 region) to see if the emails are being received by SES. If SES shows the emails but they are not being forwarded, the Lambda function may have encountered an error; check the CloudWatch Logs for the thestackone-email-forwarder function for error messages.

4.2 Gmail SMTP Configuration Error

If Gmail displays an error when trying to add the SMTP server, double-check each field against the values in Table 2. The most common mistakes are using the wrong port (465 instead of 587), selecting SSL instead of TLS, or having a typo in the SMTP server hostname. Also ensure that the username and password are copied exactly as provided, with no leading or trailing spaces. The password is case-sensitive and contains a mix of uppercase letters, lowercase letters, and digits.

4.3 Sent Emails Going to Recipients' Spam

If emails you send from chungu@thestackone.com are landing in recipients' spam folders, the domain's email authentication records (SPF, DKIM, DMARC) may need attention. These DNS records are already configured in Route 53 for thestackone.com, but if you recently made DNS changes, they can take up to 48 hours to propagate. You can verify the records using an online tool like MXToolbox or Google Admin Toolbox. The key records to check are: the SPF TXT record (which authorizes AWS SES to send email on behalf of thestackone.com), the DKIM CNAME records (which enable cryptographic email signing), and the DMARC TXT record (which tells receiving servers what to do if authentication fails).

4.4 "Via thestackone.com" Displayed on Received Emails

Some email clients, including Gmail, may display "via thestackone.com" next to the sender's name on forwarded emails. This happens because the email is relayed through the thestackone.com mail server (SES) before reaching Gmail. While this notice cannot be completely eliminated for forwarded emails (it is a security feature of email authentication), it does not affect the functionality of the email system. Recipients can still reply normally, and the original sender's information is clearly displayed in the From field alongside the via notice.

5. Technical Architecture Reference

This section provides a summary of the AWS infrastructure that powers the email system. It is intended for reference purposes and does not require any action. All resources are in the AWS us-east-1 (N. Virginia) region.

Resource	Details
AWS Account	103658463143
SES Region	us-east-1 (Production mode, 50,000 emails/day)

Route 53 Hosted Zone	Z03773932LRTBXZF0M28O
S3 Mail Bucket	thestackone-mail-inbound
Lambda Function	thestackone-email-forwarder (Node.js 20)
CloudFront Distribution	E1U3NGAMRO7AQR
SSL Certificate	thestackone.com + *.thestackone.com

Table 3: AWS resources for the StackOne email system

5.1 DNS Email Records

The following DNS records in Route 53 are critical for email functionality. The MX records direct inbound mail to AWS SES. The SPF TXT record authorizes SES to send email on behalf of thestackone.com. The DKIM CNAME records enable SES to cryptographically sign outgoing emails, and the DMARC TXT record specifies the policy for handling emails that fail authentication checks. Do not modify these records without understanding the impact, as incorrect changes can break email delivery or allow spammers to abuse your domain.

6. Security Best Practices

Protecting your email credentials is essential for maintaining the security of your email system. This section outlines important security considerations and best practices.

6.1 Protecting SMTP Credentials

The SMTP username and password listed in Table 2 grant the ability to send email from any @thestackone.com address through SES. Treat these credentials with the same level of care as your Gmail password. Do not share them with anyone who does not need to send email on behalf of the domain, and do not store them in plain-text files on shared or public systems. If you suspect the credentials have been compromised, generate new SMTP credentials in the AWS SES console immediately and update your Gmail configuration with the new values.

6.2 SES Sending Limits

The AWS SES account is in production mode with a sending limit of 50,000 emails per day. This limit is more than sufficient for normal business use. However, if you plan to send bulk emails (such as newsletters or marketing campaigns), monitor your daily sending volume through the SES dashboard to avoid hitting the limit. If you need a higher limit, you can request a sending limit increase through AWS Support.

6.3 Monitoring and Alerts

It is recommended to periodically check the CloudWatch metrics for the Lambda forwarder function and the SES sending statistics to ensure the email system is operating correctly. Set up CloudWatch Alarms for Lambda errors and SES bounce/complaint rates. A sudden spike in bounces or complaints can indicate a problem with email authentication or a potential compromise. AWS provides detailed metrics in the SES console under the "Sending Statistics" tab, including delivery rates, bounce rates, and complaint rates by domain.